We're Way Past That

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We're Way Past That

by princesscas

Summary

Phainon gets engaged to Mydei after years of being head over heels for him. The only problem: it’s a political marriage.

Notes

back at it again with a phaidei comedy! these idiots write themselves. title from the avett brothers january wedding

3.1 spoilers ahead!!!

See the end of the work for more notes

“Everyone in my goddamn kingdom hates me,” Mydei announces to the Chrysos Heirs meeting room in the back of the bathhouse.

“It’s not *your* kingdom anymore,” Anaxa reminds him benevolently, as if he thinks the semantics will solve all of Mydei’s problems.

Aglaea levels Anaxa a glare that makes Phainon wonder, not for the first time, why the two of them are ever allowed to be within sight of each other. “Please,” she says, in an equally benevolent tone. “What is so troublesome about your people?”

Mydei plunks himself down dramatically onto a fainting couch and says, “They hate me.”

Nobody bothers responding.

“And?” says Phainon, because no one else is going to say it.

“I *told* them we’re integrating into Okheman society. Like we’ve been doing for the last *twenty years.* And for some reason they’re pissed to high hell about it. Something about the bad relations between our people. They think I’m standoffish because I hate Okhemans. I’m standoffish because I hate *everyone.”*

“Ah,” says Hyacine, with a sympathetic smile. “They don’t see you publicly interacting with Okhemans, so they follow your example, right?”

Mydei huffs a sigh. “I interact with Okhemans plenty.”

“Not *publicly,”* Anaxa says. He motions vaguely to the meeting of Chrysos Heirs, which is, indeed, private. Mydei interacts almost exclusively with the other Heirs. No one outside of their own small council sees it happening.

“Well, there is *one* solution that comes to mind,” Phainon says. “If the issue is relations, all you need to do is make some.”

“Who would want to be friends with *me?* I’m terrible, Deliverer, you know that.”

“I wasn’t talking about friendship. I meant a marriage alliance.”

In the ensuing silence, Anaxa snorts.

Suddenly Phainon feels a little sweaty. “That’s a thing here, right?” he asks, just in case. “It was a thing in Aedes Elysiae. Our leader married the brother of another town’s leader for political relations.”

“It’s a thing,” Aglaea says. “A perfectly reasonable course of action,” she adds, with a pointed look in Anaxa’s direction. Anaxa rolls his eyes at her as though he’d quite enjoy punching her in her divine face.

“So you can do the same thing,” Phainon says. “Just with an Okheman societal figure instead.”

“Who,” Mydei says drily.

Phainon frowns. That’s a tough one. “Well, they have to be Okheman, obviously. Preferably someone well-known. They have to be a strong warrior with a few achievements to their name, so that your people respect them. Oh, and with your library obsession, they should at least dabble in scholarly pursuits. They should be social, to take some of the heat of political interactions off of you. Ideally they would be interested in Kremnoan traditions and language, but that’s negotiable. And they ought to be someone you know already, and someone you don’t mind spending time with. Someone you like.”

Utter silence.

“What?” Phainon says. “Was it something I said?”

“Deliverer,” says Mydei. “You essentially gave me one option.”

Phainon is a little surprised there’s even *one*, actually. He thought he’d have eliminated everyone. “Well, that’s great! Who is it?”

Everyone in the room looks at him.

Phainon waits.

Everyone keeps looking at him.

“…Oh,” says Phainon.

“Uh huh,” says Mydei.

“Well, that’s settled,” says Aglaea diplomatically, smoothing out her dress as she stands up. “I assume you’re both free three days from now? If not, clear your schedules. Anaxa will make the announcement, and I’ll officiate.”

“Sorry,” says Anaxa. “Can’t hear you from the bus you just threw me under.”

“Shut your damn mouth,” says Aglaea very politely.

Anaxa shuts his damn mouth.

“Wait,” says Phainon, throwing himself in front of the door before Aglaea can leave. “It isn’t *settled.* What if I don’t *want* to go through with this? Like, what if I want to get married to someone I’m in love with?”

“You’re not in love with me?” Mydei asks, sounding a little surprised.

“He is,” says Aglaea. “Clear your schedule three days from now. I’m thinking sunset, but if you prefer a different time, let me know.”

“Sunset is fine,” Mydei says.

“Aglaea,” Phainon cries, scandalized. “You can’t just *tell him* that.”

“Why not? Everyone knew already. Phainon, sunset?”

“Aughghghgh,” says Phainon. He kind of hates Aglaea sometimes. Then, “Sunset is fine.”

“Perfect.” And without further ado, Aglaea moves him aside by his shoulders and walks out the door. Phainon watches her leave with a vague sense of despair building in his stomach.

“So,” says Anaxa. “Any chance you want to write your own wedding invitations?”

“I can do it, Professor Anaxa,” Hyacine pipes up, beaming.

Mydei stands up and crosses his arms. “Stop letting people walk all over you.”

“She’s *my* assistant,” Anaxa grumbles, but doesn’t actually object to the charges. Phainon remembers his class; poor Hyacine was running laps around that classroom. Phainon used to feel tired just watching her.

“It’s *your* job,” Mydei reminds him. “You’re the one who should do it.”

“I fucking hate Aglaea,” Anaxa mutters, pacing back and forth. “These are going to be the most beautiful wedding invitations the world has ever motherfucking *seen.* That’ll show her.”

Didn’t she ask you to do exactly that, Phainon thinks, but doesn’t say anything. He just nods. “Thanks, Professor.”

“Thanks, old man,” Mydei echoes.

Anaxa glares at him. “I can and will spell your name wrong on the invitation.”

“Please don’t,” Phainon says quickly. A mistake in the wedding invitation might count as a declaration of war in Kremnoan culture. He’s not entirely sure.

“Ugh, *fine,”* says Anaxa, because he’s actually a terrible pushover who has never denied Phainon anything. “You have terrible taste. Next time, choose a better one.”

“Next time?” Phainon asks, bemused, but Anaxa has already left.

Hyacine’s eyes flicker between the two of them, and she grins. “Have fun! Be safe! No unwanted pregnancies!” Then she flounces out the door right behind the professor.

“HYACINE,” Phainon yells after her, scandalized. She doesn’t look back. He sighs.

“So,” says Mydei. “Looks like it’s just you and me again.”

“Shut *up,”* says Phainon. “I don’t want to hear it from you.”

“You have a crush on me.”

Phainon glares at him. He thought it might come to this. “No. In fact I despise you deeply with all of my soul.”

“You want to get married.”

“I am being *coerced* into—”

“You want me to have your children.”

“—this marriage and it’s not—wait, you can get pregnant?”

Mydei shrugs. “Maybe.”

“WHAT DO YOU MEAN, MAYBE?”

“I mean maybe,” Mydei says, like it’s completely inconsequential. “Kremnoans have different biology depending on their heritage. No one really taught me the ins and outs.”

“And you…” Phainon takes one look at him and decides he gives up. “You know what? Whatever. I’ll just bottom.”

“What a sacrifice, Deliverer,” Mydei drawls. “You gave in so fast it almost makes me think you wanted that from the beginning.”

“Well,” says Phainon, his face burning. He gestures vaguely at Mydei’s entire Thing. “I mean. Like. Look at you.”

Mydei grins. “No, no, go on. Please.”

“You,” says Phainon, “are without a doubt the least likeable person I’ve ever had the displeasure of being infatuated with.”

“You *like* me,” Mydei says, still grinning. “That’s so embarrassing for you.”

“I’m *leaving.”*

“You want to make *love* with me.”

“LEAVING,” Phainon calls from the door, which he has not actually left from yet, although he’s had ample time to.

“You want me to be your wife and cook you breakfast every—”

“Oh my fucking *god,”* Phainon says, and turns around to kiss him stupid, because that’s how this shit always goes.

Twenty minutes later they are, once again, kicked out of the bathhouse.

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“You know, maybe I’ll put *that* on the invitations,” Anaxa muses. “‘A union between two people banned from the public bathhouses a total of twelve times for being a public disturbance.’ Do you think people will like that?”

“It wasn’t *twelve* times,” Phainon scoffs. Then he actually thinks about it for a minute. “…Okay, maybe ten. Or eleven.”

“It was twelve,” Anaxa says grimly.

Okay, it was probably twelve. Phainon isn’t going to admit defeat though, so he says, “I don’t think twelve is that bad. How many times have you been banned from the bathhouse?”

“One.”

“Oh.”

“It was a lifetime ban, though. One time Aglaea told me to kill myself and I actually tried to do it. Put my head under the water and everything.”

“…Professor,” says Phainon, suddenly a little worried. “Are you, like, okay?”

Anaxa waves a hand vaguely. “Totally fine. I didn’t actually breathe in. I just thought it would be funny. She pulled me back out after about five seconds.”

That doesn’t make Phainon any *less* worried. “Well, at least Aglaea put her foot down,” he says hopefully. “She must care about you a little bit, right?”

Anaxa barks out a single sharp laugh. “No. I told her she was a fake hater for saving me. That pissed her off so bad that she shoved me back into the bath. *Then* she banned me.”

“Huh,” says Phainon. Aglaea is always so professional with him—maybe a little exasperated, but consistently composed and polite. It’s hard to imagine Aglaea being petty. He thought she gave up all her emotions, but apparently spite is still very much present.

“Anyway, one time. Not twelve.”

“I think yours might be worse,” Phainon says weakly.

“At least mine weren’t for having public sex.”

Phainon drops his head onto Anaxa’s desk with a clunk. “Professor, we are in your *office.* Is nothing sacred?”

“The bathhouse apparently isn't.”

“For the record, we were NOT having public sex in there,” Phainon tells him, lifting his head just slightly off the desk. “We’re just really competitive. And we get invested in it.”

Anaxa doesn’t even say anything. He just looks up from his elegant stationery with an unimpressed jaunt to his eyebrows.

“Well, maybe once,” Phainon says, a little nervously. “Or twice.”

“Phainon.”

Phainon sighs and buries his face in his hands. “Professor,” he says in despair. “You can’t expect me to tell you about my sex life. You taught my college classes. You were my *debate coach.”*

“And now I’m writing your wedding invitations, apparently,” Anaxa says. “Fuck you,” he says to something else on the table. Phainon peers at it curiously. It’s a framed portrait of Aglaea. It’s the only picture on his desk.

“Professor, why…”

Anaxa looks at him with a measured, neutral expression that scares the shit out of him. “Choose your next words very carefully.”

“…How are the invitations going?” Phainon says instead, because he likes being alive and wants to continue being that way.

“Take a look for yourself.”

Anaxa slides a piece of thick paper across the table. Inked on it is quite possibly the most beautiful sketch Phainon has ever seen. It depicts two people back-to-back, the silhouettes of their faces illuminated by the setting sun behind them. Somehow Anaxa has managed to capture the exact positions each of them defends in while fighting, making them look combat-ready and impressively in sync with one another.

“Holy fucking shit,” Phainon marvels, lifting the drawing off the table to examine it better. “Is that me and Mydei?”

“Who the fuck else would it be?”

Right. Yeah. Stupid question. Directly underneath their two figures are their names and the year and date. “This is amazing.”

Anaxa crosses his arms. “What, you thought I’d half-ass this? Of course not. I’m proving a point to Aglaea, remember?”

“You can just say you like me,” Phainon says. “Everyone knows I was your favorite student.”

“You were a goddamn terror,” Anaxa tells him flatly. “Now get out so I can write the bit about the twelve bathhouse bans.”

“Professor, you wouldn’t actually…”

“I would.”

His eyes are too calm to be bluffing. Phainon hastily gets up from the professor’s desk. “Thanks for everything, Professor Anaxa,” he says quickly, and then makes for the door like his life depends on it.

“IT’S ANAXAGORAS, YOU FOOLISH—”

Phainon grins as the door falls shut behind him.

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The Heirs meeting where his fate was decided wasn’t a formal event, so Castorice wasn’t even there. Thus it falls to Phainon to go to her house and tell her himself. He’s sweating buckets as he knocks on her door. For good measure, he calls, “It’s Phainon,” because he knows Castorice hates answering the door, especially for strangers.

Castorice opens the door a few inches, peeks one eye out, and then upon seeing him opens the door all the way. “Hello,” she says politely. “To what do I owe the pleasure?”

“I’m not here on business.”

“Oh.” Castorice tilts her head and looks at him funny. “Come in, then. I’ll make tea.”

“I don’t need—”

“I,” says Castorice firmly, “will *make you tea.*”

“Okay, sure,” says Phainon, because any good warrior knows when to retreat. He steps over the threshold.

Castorice’s house is covered in protective talismans. The instant he steps inside, he feels the blessings wash over him like a sudden chill. Normally talismans provide a comforting effect, but the sheer volume of protections on her house makes it almost unpleasant, like shivers down his spine. She refuses to let anyone close to her without them, though, so he puts up with the odd feeling and takes a seat on the lounge in her reception room.

For a few minutes he sits there in silence while Castorice busies herself brewing the tea. Usually Phainon doesn’t like silence, but with Castorice it isn’t awkward or clunky. Silence with her is peaceful. The talismans hum in the background, making him feel strangely content.

Eventually Castorice brings the teapot out and sets it on the table. She takes a seat next to him and says, “This one’s new. It’s called tieguanyin. Dan Heng says it’s from his homeland.”

Castorice dumps a metric fuckton of sugar into his tea for him and then hands it over. Phainon takes it gratefully. He doesn’t like his tea too strong, but Castorice loves the bitterness. The sugar is their compromise.

Phainon waits until Castorice has lifted the teacup to her mouth to say, “Cas, I’m getting married.”

He expects this to be some grand revelation. In his mind’s eye Castorice spits out her tea all over the table and stares at him with wide, baffled eyes. In his mind’s eye she says, *Really, Phainon? What the hell? This is the most unexpected news I’ve had in all six years we’ve known each other. You? Tying the knot? With who, pray tell? I’ve never been so shocked in all my life.* Or something to that effect. Maybe not so many words. Castorice doesn’t talk quite like that.

Reality is, by contrast, entirely anticlimactic. She just nods and continues drinking her tea.

Phainon stares at her. “I’m getting *married,”* he repeats, just in case that wasn’t clear. “I’m going to be someone’s *husband.”*

“That is generally what happens, yes,” says Castorice. “What do you think of this? I quite like the flavor. It’s bold, but not overly medicinal.”

“Cas,” says Phainon urgently, setting down his cup. “Cas, *I’m getting married in two days.”*

“That’s a bit soon. Accidental pregnancy?”

Phainon groans and buries his head in his hands.

“I suppose not,” says Castorice, shifting her legs awkwardly in lieu of touching him. “The political climate, then? I heard something about Kremnoan unrest following Mydei’s abdication.”

Phainon glances up at her, raising his eyebrows. He never told her *who* he was marrying. “Did someone already tell you?”

“No.”

“Then how did you know it was Mydei?”

Castorice looks at him, confused, over the rim of her cup. “Who else would it be?”

“Um,” says Phainon, because he hasn’t actually thought that far. It’s a tough question. “I dunno. Like… Hyacine, maybe?”

“Hyacine is a priestess. She’s sworn to celibacy.”

Right. Phainon doesn’t know how he forgot about that; she was always kindly rejecting suitors back at the Grove, and giving them gorgeous smiles while they cried their eyes out over it. “Well, uh…” He tries going through everyone he knows. Hyacine wouldn’t. Aglaea is out of the question, obviously. Anaxa is too old for him and was also his professor, which feels weird. Cipher doesn’t even like him. And Castorice would probably know if they were engaged. “Maybe you don’t know them,” Phainon tries. “Maybe

I’m getting married to a Council member or something to improve Council-Heirs relations.”

“You aren’t,” Castorice says. “You’re marrying Mydei.”

Phainon gives up. “Yeah. Okay. I am.”

“Well, don’t sound so distraught about it,” Castorice tells him, nudging his teacup closer to him on the table. “I for one am quite happy about this news.”

Phainon looks at her. Her expression is completely and utterly neutral, just like it always is. “I’m happy,” he says in despair. “Of course I am.”

A miniscule frown crosses Castorice’s mouth. “You are lying. What could possibly make you unhappy about this arrangement? Aren’t you in love with him?”

“Why does EVERYONE know about that,” Phainon says, throwing his hands in the air at some higher being. “Maybe a guy wants to keep his feelings to himself sometimes.”

“You told me,” says Castorice. “Seven times.”

“Well,” says Phainon.

“You also described to me, in detail, the manner in which you had sex in the public bathhouse.”

Phainon sighs. He probably did do that. It sounds like something he would do.

“By all measures you ought to be delighted about marrying him,” says Castorice. Then she sets down her teacup and looks at him expectantly.

Phainon feels his resolve shatter, right then.

“He doesn’t even *like me*, Cas,” he cries, clutching her sleeve like it’s her hand. “Cas, he thinks I’m weird and overbearing and too nerdy. His people

probably won't even like me and then he'll think, *This wasn't worth it,* and then he'll ask me to get divorced and I'll have to say yes and regret it for the rest of my life. And he'll hate me forever and I'll die alone and they'll write about me in the history books as Mydeimos the Undying's worst spouse ever."

Castorice raises a single eyebrow about half a millimeter. "Why would he marry you if he did not like you? Is a marital union not traditionally made for love?"

"Cas, it's a *political marriage.*"

"Oh," says Castorice.

"Yeah," says Phainon.

"Hm," says Castorice.

"I know," says Phainon.

"Ah," says Castorice.

"Tell me about it," says Phainon.

Castorice sighs. "This calls for extreme measures, I think."

Ten minutes later she reappears with another full teapot, a bottle of muscat wine, a pajama robe, and a bottle of blue nail polish. "Give me your hands," she demands, pulling on her thick leather gloves. "I'm painting them."

Phainon gives her his hands. Castorice paints his nails shittily because the gloves are too stiff to allow full movement. Then he puts on the pajama robe and drinks the wine with her while they complain and cry. It's the most fun he's had in weeks.

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He wakes up on Castorice's couch with a mild headache and no shirt on.

“Cas?” he calls to the house. It echoes back to him.

“Uh huh,” says Castorice from under the couch. She rolls on the floor so that just her head sticks out from underneath. “I’m here.”

Phainon blinks. “Did you sleep there?”

“No,” says Castorice. “I don’t sleep.”

“…I see,” says Phainon, although he does not. “Well, I ought to be going, I guess. Getting married in two days and all that.”

“Tomorrow.”

“Tomorrow,” Phainon corrects himself. “Wow. Okay. Yeah. Tomorrow.”

Castorice rolls herself up from the floor. She somehow looks perfectly composed when she stands up. No one could tell that she had spent the night underneath her own couch. Phainon wonders, just briefly, if she does this every night. “I’ll be there.”

“You fucking *better,*” Phainon tells her. “I did not spend three years forcing you into being my friend for you to *not* show up to my wedding.”

“Your political wedding,” Castorice says. “To the man you’re actually in love with.”

“Yeah,” says Phainon, suddenly remembering his own predicament. “Well. That’s life, I guess.” He sets his hand on the doorknob.

“You should probably put a shirt on before going out.”

“OH,” says Phainon, clearing his throat. He’s still wearing Castorice’s pajama robe. “Right. Where exactly *is* my shirt? For that matter, where are the *rest* of my clothes??”

Castorice just shrugs.

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“We know,” says Tribbie, before he can even open his mouth.

“Congratulations,” Trinnon adds in a small voice, sounding like she’d rather not admit that she’s happy about it.

“…Okay,” says Phainon. He kind of forgot that Tribios is a demigod too. They would naturally Know Things with weird divine premonitions. “Will you be there?”

“Of course, Snowy!” says Tribbie, with a gentle smile. She floats up to pat his head. “We’ve been waiting for you and De to get married for years. Trianne used to always ask about it—she was getting impatient. She’ll be happy it’s finally happening.”

“Oh,” says Phainon, suddenly a little sad. He smiles anyway. “Well, when I see her next, I’ll be sure to tell her all about it.”

“Thank you,” says Trinnon, bowing her head.

“Please bring some flowers to the wedding. Whichever were Trianne’s favorites.”

Tribbie beams and gives him a short bow. “Of course we will, Snowy.”

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The actual wedding is overwhelming. Somehow Phainon had underestimated how many people knew him, and knew Mydei, and would show up to see them get married. It seems like every single person in Okhema is in the central plaza when he shows up at the altar.

“Holy shit,” he says to Aglaea, who is already present, and would probably rather die than be more than two minutes late to anything. She’s in a full gold dress today, because she’s too classy to wear white to a wedding even if there’s no bride. “You weren’t kidding about the publicity.”

“That man did an excellent job,” she mutters, as if she’d rather not admit it.

She must be talking about Anaxa. “I know,” Phainon gushes. “I went to go see him and he ran the drafts by me and *wow.* Prof is even more talented than I thought he was.”

Aglaea’s nose scrunches up about two millimeters. “Don’t flatter him. He’s still a fool.”

“Well,” says Phainon, because if Anaxa is a fool, Phainon must be idiotic beyond measure. He decides to change tracks. “Isn’t Mydei supposed to be up here?”

Aglaea looks at him oddly. “Didn’t he tell you? He’ll be walking down the aisle just before sunset. I presume he’ll have the whole Kremnoan entourage with him, as well; they’ll all be entering after him.”

This is the crowd *without* the Kremnoans? Holy shit.

“Then you’ll be having the customary no-weapons duel, and the vows, and the pouring of the mead. We’ve skipped out on the animal sacrifices—Mydei didn’t want any omens of death at the wedding.”

“The duel,” Phainon says, a little blankly. “Yeah. Of course. The vows. And the mead. Totally.”

Aglaea sighs through her nose. It sounds, to the well-trained ear, very much like giving up.

Castorice shows up a few minutes later, decked out in an incredible purple gown with a six-foot hoop skirt. “So no one comes near me,” she explains to him, utterly deadpan. Between her and Aglaea, Phainon feels criminally underdressed, and it’s *his* damn wedding. He’s wearing his Deliverer’s armor, like usual, but with a black version of his coat and pants. It felt, at the time, like an authentic and battle-ready ensemble that the Kremnoans might appreciate. Now he thinks he might be an idiot.

“It’s fine,” Castorice tells him, before he even says anything. “You look quite alright. Don’t worry yourself.”

He glances at her face. Her expression is completely and utterly neutral. “You’re kind of creepy sometimes,” he says, a little warily.

“A ‘thanks’ would do just fine.”

Phainon rolls his eyes at her.

“Kids,” says a familiar voice. “Stop fighting.”

Phainon turns around, delighted. “Professor!”

“Yeah, yeah, I’m the greatest and you love me,” Anaxa says, glaring at him. “Don’t touch me. I nearly killed myself organizing this. This body is one good punch away from disintegrating.”

“Oh, good,” says Aglaea, and summons a garmentmaker, fists out.

“HEY,” says Anaxa.

“Not at my wedding,” Phainon pleads. “Wait until tomorrow at least.”

Aglaea looks faintly offended. “I wouldn’t *kill* him.”

“Bold words for someone who just actively tried to kill me,” says Anaxa, sounding delighted about it. “You want a rematch? One coreflame versus another? I’ll be happy to oblige.”

“Kill yourself,” says Aglaea serenely.

“In front of the kids?”

“GUYS,” says Castorice loudly. She points vaguely at the other end of the courtyard.

Across from them, the entire Kremnoan contingent is coming into view. They hold towering banners of red and gold and approach like a crashing wave. At the very front is their former king, looking just the same as always except for the paint across his chest, which is white instead of red.

“Holy shit,” Phainon breathes.

“You *would* say that,” Anaxa mutters.

Aglaea looks about two seconds away from slapping him across the face. “Get back to the audience, you buffoon.”

Anaxa complies. Castorice, too, disappears off the stage, though as the maid of honor she stands just off to the right rather than fleeing.

Mydei doesn’t walk down the aisle so much as part the sea of onlookers. The effect is only increased by Tribbie and Trinnon floating behind him, showering little white flower petals everywhere like ash after a fire. It’s incredible, how everyone moves out of his way like he’s someone important, someone powerful. And he *is*, Phainon remembers abruptly. He’s the god of strife, now. He’s the third-most powerful person in Amphoreus, and the other two are both so well-established that thinking of their weddings feels blasphemous. But Mydei? Mydei is just right to motivate everyone. A new god, a new king, a new *everything.*

Phainon can’t believe *he’s* the person on the receiving end of all this grandeur. He’s no one—just a local, a personality, a familiar face at the market. He’s not a hero, not like Mydei is.

And yet here he is, a voice says quietly in his mind. Here he is, just as celebrated as the demigods on either side of him. Here he is, just as much of a hero as any of them.

Phainon doesn’t believe that voice, not quite yet. But someday. Someday, he will.

Just before Mydei reaches the pavilion Aglaea set up for the ceremony, he raises his hand in invitation. “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” he says, his pronunciation careful. It makes Phainon’s chest clench, imagining him practicing shaping the words of his hometown in his mouth for this moment. “I challenge you to a duel.”

This, at least, Phainon knows intimately well. He steps down from the pavilion, putting them on even ground. Somehow he can't seem to wipe the grin from his own face. "Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos," he echoes. "I accept."

And then Mydei is lunging for the weak spot on his right side. Phainon swings himself to the left, avoiding him, and grabs his arm to whirl him back around, like a dance partner. It's worth using so much strength to catch a glimpse of the surprise and, if he isn't mistaken, delight on Mydei's face.

They've dueled a thousand times before, but never so publicly. Never for entertainment. Mydei goes for his shoulder; Phainon counters by sweeping at his ankles. Mydei raises the ground beneath him; Phainon kicks him in the chest hard enough to have him staggering backwards. Mydei dodges a clever attempt at getting behind him to strike his back; Phainon narrowly avoids a manifested spear through the chest by throwing himself backwards through the air, spiraling above the blade. It's like dancing, Phainon thinks, exhilarated. Just like dancing together.

And when Phainon finally falls to his blades, it's with absolute delight that he concedes victory to Mydei.

"I told you," he murmurs as Mydei pulls him back to his feet. "May victory always be yours, Mydeimos."

Mydei makes a sound halfway to a laugh. Phainon considers this an absolute win.

Back on the stage, Aglaea welcomes them both to stand facing each other, the reverse of their stance on the invitations. "As the victor of this fight," she announces to the entire fucking city, "Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos, please make your declarations of intent."

Phainon expects a lot of things, here. He wouldn't be surprised if Mydei framed it politically, talking about becoming part of an Okheman-Kremnoan alliance. Maybe he'll go totally textbook and say something bland about lives spent together and deaths doing part and whatnot. He even

wonders if Mydei will forego all of that and say something about Phainon's skill as a warrior, praising his ability to keep up with him.

What he does *not* expect is for Mydei to drop to one knee.

"Deliverer," he says, so quiet that even Aglaea's magnification spell has to work to pick it up. Then, louder, "Phainon."

Phainon stares at him. He's been silent a little too long. "Yes?" he asks, faintly amused. He knew Mydei would be awkward about this, but this is really something.

"The King of Kremnos has to be bested by his lover to take them as a spouse."

Phainon's heart sinks.

Does that mean—just because he *lost* to the literal *god of strife,* the wedding is—

"But I am not king," Mydei says, lifting his head. "I am only Mydeimos. And I want you to marry me as such. So I kneel before you: the finest I have ever sparred with, the wittiest I have ever conversed with, and the worthiest I have ever placed my trust in. And I ask—" He pauses here, looking conflicted, but continues. "—I ask that you permit me to stand beside you as long as we both live."

Phainon blinks.

Mydei looks away from him.

"Well, get up," Phainon says, offering his hand. "It's weird looking down at you. We're usually on equal footing."

Mydei takes his hand. Phainon pulls him back up.

"Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," Aglaea rudely interrupts, because they were having a very intense silent conversation just then. "How do you respond to this declaration of love?"

“Well, I accept, obviously,” Phainon says without thinking. Then, “Wait, declaration of WHAT??”

“Love,” Aglaea repeats slowly.

“I heard you,” Phainon says, a little faint. “But—okay, hold on. Turn off the —” He motions vaguely to Aglaea, who presumably shuts off the voice amplifier. He turns back around and whispers, “Mydei, what is she talking about?”

“A declaration of love,” says Mydei, raising his eyebrows. “That thing I just did. You *just* said yes to it. Keep up.”

“No, but—I don’t—you don’t like me.”

Mydei looks genuinely baffled. “Why would I marry you if I didn’t like you?”

“For the—you *know why!”*

“Deliverer,” Mydei says slowly. “One of your prerequisites was that I *liked* the person.”

Phainon blinks. Did he say that? “But you said there was only one option.”

“Because *you’re* the only person I like.”

Phainon gapes at him.

“Don’t look at me like that,” Mydei grumbles, crossing his arms. His face is flushed. “You *know* that I’m in love with you. We’ve been dating for *five years*, Deliverer. Don’t act surprised.”

“I wasn’t *acting—WAIT, FIVE YEARS??”*

“Yeah.”

“That’s when we *met,”* Phainon hisses. “I was still in *college.* We didn’t even start hooking up until two years after that. How the hell did you get

the idea that we were *dating* back then??”

“You beat me in a duel,” Mydei says, like it’s just that simple. “And when I asked what you wanted, you said, *Your hand in marriage.* So here we are.”

“I DID NOT SAY THAT!”

“You did,” says Mydei, and damn it, he’s probably right. Phainon says a lot of shit. He wouldn’t have *known,* back then, that he’d actually follow through on it. “I thought that was why you brought up marriage alliances in the first place.”

“It was a genuine suggestion,” Phainon says, a little despairingly. “I really did mean to suggest marriage for political reasons. You can still try finding someone else if you like. A lavender marriage or whatever.”

“Deliverer,” says Mydei flatly. “Don’t be fucking stupid.”

Phainon sighs. “Yeah,” he mumbles. “Yeah, okay, no more stupidity. You already know I’m in love with you—because apparently EVERYONE knows that, what the hell—so let’s just… you know…”

“Let’s just what?” says Mydei, because he’s a little bastard.

Phainon glares at him. “You know.”

“No,” says Mydei, a tiny smile tugging at the corner of his mouth. “No, I don’t think I do, actually.”

“YOU KNOW.”

“I have no idea what you’re—”

“Fuck’s sake,” Phainon says, and lunges for him like he’ll never get another chance.

The stupid look on Mydei’s face when Phainon kisses him is worth all the shit they’re going to get from Aglaea.

***

“So what *were* your wedding vows?” asks Trinnon the next day, during the massive lunch banquet in the bathhouse. The wedding was so grand that the partying lasted through the night and just sort of continued, and now the celebration is still going like it just began. They’re all hiding in the Chrysos Heirs bath, because everywhere else is too overrun with partying citizens. “No one got to hear Phainon’s.”

“They were really dirty,” Phainon says without hesitation. “Not suitable for children. You know.”

“Yeah,” says Mydei. “Super filthy stuff. Nasty. Just vile.”

“By far the most explicit stuff I’ve ever said.”

“Seriously. I can’t *believe* some of the things that came out of this guy's mouth.”

Phainon narrows his eyes at him. “Don’t *‘this guy’* me. I’m your *husband.”*

“Shut the fuck up,” Mydei tells him, without hesitating for even a second.

Phainon grins. Some things never change.

“The vows were really dumb, weren’t they,” says Trinnon, sighing heavily.

“Yeah,” says Castorice. “*Really* dumb. Unbelievably dumb.”

Phainon turns to her, fake appalled. “Rude! You’re supposed to be my best friend.”

“He thought you’d been dating for five years. And you thought he didn’t even *like you.”*

“…Okay, maybe it seems bad from a certain perspective,” Phainon says. “Or from most perspectives. Including my own. But you know. I’m just a guy.”

“No,” says Mydei, with a stupid grin. “You’re my husband.”

“Oh my *god,*” says Phainon. “You’re so bad. You’re the actual worst.”

“And you married me.”

Phainon looks at him and his dumb smirk and thinks it’s a damn shame that he likes him so much.

“You *like* me,” Mydei drawls. “You have a *crush* on me. You want to make *love* with me and eat the breakfast I cook every—”

Phainon rolls his eyes and drags him by the hair to kiss him.

Behind them, Tribbie and Trinnon and Castorice make the world’s most inconspicuous exit.

***

“Make that thirteen,” Anaxa says, with a half-sympathetic, half-mocking nod. “I have to say, I really respect it. Thirteen times might be a new record.”

Phainon drops his head onto Anaxa’s office desk. He groans in despair.

“You were even in a semi-private space. It takes a *lot* to get kicked out of those.”

Phainon looks up from the desk to make pathetic eye contact with him. “Professor, it’s so weird that you know about my sex life now. I think twenty year old me would die if he heard about this.”

“If you want to get even, I can tell you about—”

“Nonono,” Phainon interrupts. “Do not tell me. I do not want to know.”

“Why not? It could be your insurance.”

Phainon sighs heavily and drags himself to sit upright again. “I don’t know why I even bother with you. I could just go home to my husband whom I love dearly and who apparently adores me to the ends of the earth.”

“Apparently?” Anaxa scoffs. “Even *I* could tell that boy liked you when you were at the Grove, and I saw him *twice*. He isn’t exactly a master of subtlety.”

“You *knew??*”

“Everyone in Amphoreus knew.”

Phainon buries his face in his hands. “Professor,” he says, and finally faces the truth he’s been avoiding this whole time: “I think I might actually be an idiot.”

End Notes

and then they live happily ever after and NOTHING BAD HAPPENS and NO SHENANIGANS ARE PULLED hoyo do you HEAR ME. no shenanigans whatsoever. just silliness for the rest of their days

please drop a comment / kudos if you enjoyed! i am so obsessed with the 3.1 update. i’m genuinely losing my mind over it. my friends unfortunately know this very well because they’ve been forced to tolerate my screaming for the last two weeks. hopefully some of you can help release the burden on my poor friends by screaming with me here

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